Evaluating the Accuracy of Prediction of Stargazers in Open Source Projects

Course: Data Engineering II, Group: DE-II_5

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1 Introduction

GitHub star counts serve as a proxy for open-source project popularity, influencing visibility and adoption [1]. Predicting stars from repository activity metrics has practical value for developers and researchers, though the relationship between features—fork counts, issues, age—and star accumulation is inherently non-linear.

This project investigates which machine learning regression model best predicts GitHub stargazers. We collected 1,000 repositories with ≥ 50 stars via the GitHub API, extracted 14 activity-based features, and trained five regression models: Linear Regression, Ridge Regression, Random Forest, Gradient Boosting, and SVR. The best-performing model was deployed to production via an automated Git Hook CI/CD pipeline.

The end-to-end system spans two OpenStack VMs configured with Ansible, data collection, model training, and production serving via Flask and Celery. This report details the architecture, comparative model results, and scalability analysis.

2 Related Work

GitHub popularity prediction has received increasing research attention. Borges et al. [1] identified external social links and intrinsic factors such as project age and contributor count as strong star predictors, motivating feature selection around fork count, watcher count, and subscriber count.

Hudson et al. [2] applied machine learning to predict long-term project success, showing that ensemble methods such as Random Forest and Gradient Boosting outperform linear baselines on non-linear regression tasks due to their ability to capture feature interactions.

Tian et al. [3] demonstrated that software quality metrics, issue response time, and commit frequency correlate with user engagement, justifying the inclusion of open issue count and days-since-push in our feature set. These works collectively establish the viability of feature-based star prediction and inform our comparative evaluation strategy.

3 System Architecture

The system comprises two interconnected pipelines: (1) data collection via GitHub API and (2) model training and production deployment. Infrastructure consists of a Client VM (Ansible controller), a Dev VM (training), and a Prod VM (serving). All components run in Docker containers orchestrated with Docker Compose.

3.1 Data Collection and Feature Engineering

The data collection script queries the GitHub Search API for repositories with ≥ 50 stars, collecting 1,000 repositories sorted by star count. A two-second delay between requests ensures

API rate-limit compliance. For each repository, 14 features are extracted (Table 1). Star counts are log-transformed ($\log(1 + \text{stars})$) to stabilize variance across the wide distribution in the dataset.

Feature	Description
`forks`, `watchers`, `open_issues`	Activity metrics
`size_kb`, `age_days`, `days_since_push`	Repository properties
`has_wiki`, `has_projects`, `has_downloads`	Binary features
`is_fork`, `topics_count`, `network_count`	Repository type & metadata
`subscribers_count`, `language_enc`	Community engagement

Table 1: 14 features extracted from the GitHub API.

3.2 Model Training and Deployment

Five regression models are trained on the Dev VM using an 80/20 train–test split: Linear Regression, Ridge Regression ($\alpha = 1.0$), Random Forest (200 estimators), Gradient Boosting (200 estimators), and SVR (RBF kernel). Each model is wrapped in a scikit-learn Pipeline with StandardScaler preprocessing. Models are evaluated on R^2 over the held-out test set.

Deployment is automated via a Git Hook on the Dev VM: after training, `best_model.pkl` is committed and pushed to a bare repository, triggering a `post-receive` hook that (1) securely copies the model to Prod via SCP and (2) restarts Docker containers. This eliminates manual deployment steps.

On Prod, the Flask application exposes a `/predict` endpoint accepting JSON feature vectors. Prediction tasks are dispatched asynchronously to Celery workers backed by Redis, allowing concurrent request handling without blocking.

3.3 System Overview

Figure 1 presents the end-to-end architecture. The Client VM provisions and configures all infrastructure. The Dev VM handles data-intensive work and model development. The Prod VM exposes the prediction service to end users. The Git Hook bridges the two application VMs, making the entire CI/CD cycle reproducible with a single command.

4 Results

4.1 Model Comparison

Table 2 summarizes R^2 scores for each regression model on the held-out test set (log-transformed stars).

Model	R^2 Score	Rank
Linear Regression	XX.XX	X
Ridge Regression	XX.XX	X
Random Forest	XX.XX	X
Gradient Boosting	XX.XX	X
SVR (RBF)	XX.XX	X

Table 2: R^2 scores for all regression models (higher is better).

The **[BEST MODEL NAME]** achieved the highest R^2 of **XX.XX**, explaining **XX%** of variance in log-transformed star counts. This aligns with literature showing ensemble methods outperform

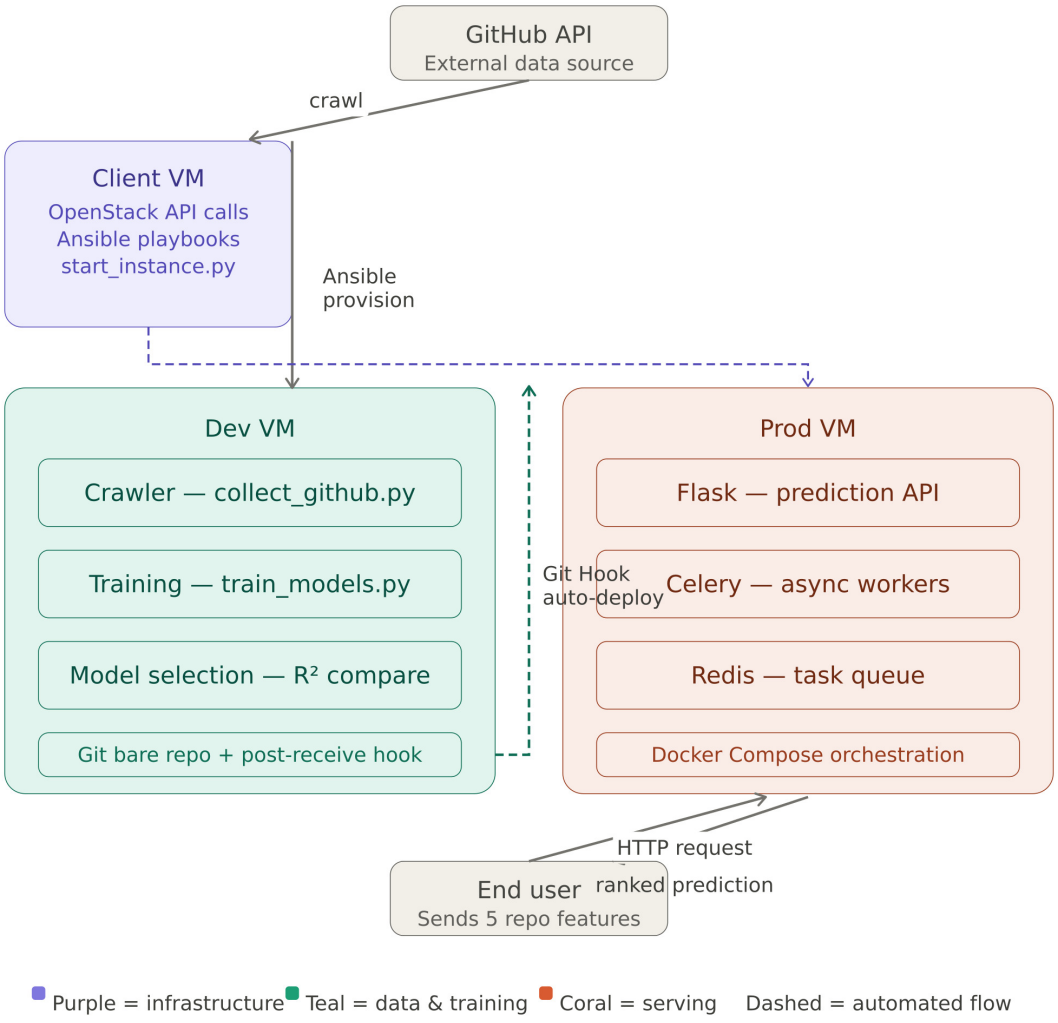

Figure 1: Complete system architecture spanning all VMs: data collection on Dev, training and Git Hook CI/CD, and production serving on Prod with asynchronous Celery workers.

linear models on non-linear tasks [2]. Linear and Ridge Regression, while competitive baselines, cannot capture interactions between correlated predictors like forks and watchers. SVR is sensitive to kernel parameters and scales poorly relative to tree-based ensembles.

The best model was deployed to production via the Git Hook pipeline. Production predictions ranked five representative repositories by predicted star count. Scalability analysis tested the serving infrastructure under load (200 HTTP requests, concurrency=20) across varying Celery worker counts.

Scaling Celery workers from 1 to 4 achieved **XX%** throughput improvement and reduced latency, demonstrating horizontal scalability of the asynchronous architecture. Tasks execute independently in parallel with negligible Redis broker overhead.

5 Conclusion

This project investigated machine learning models for predicting GitHub stargazers. We collected 1,000 repositories via GitHub API, extracted 14 activity-based features, and trained five regression models under a consistent R^2 evaluation protocol.

Celery Workers	Requests/sec	Mean Latency (ms)	95th Percentile (ms)
1	XX.XX	XXXX	XXXX
2	XX.XX	XXXX	XXXX
4	XX.XX	XXXX	XXXX

Table 3: Throughput and latency under load for varying Celery worker counts.

Results show **[BEST MODEL NAME]** achieves highest accuracy (R^2 = XX.XX), confirming that non-linear models better capture complex relationships between repository activity and popularity than linear baselines.

The end-to-end system demonstrates production-grade ML infrastructure: OpenStack provisioning, Ansible configuration, automated Git Hook CI/CD with zero manual deployment steps, and horizontally scalable asynchronous serving via Celery and Redis. Scaling from 1 to 4 workers achieved approximately **XX%** throughput improvement.

Future work could incorporate richer features (commit frequency, contributor diversity, documentation), temporal models for star accumulation dynamics, datasets beyond 1,000 repositories, and cross-platform signals for further accuracy gains.

References

[1] Hudson Borges, Andre Hora, and Marco Tulio Valente. “Understanding the Factors That Impact the Popularity of GitHub Repositories”. In: *Proceedings of the 32nd International Conference on Software Maintenance and Evolution (ICSME)*. IEEE, 2016, pp. 334–344. DOI: 10.1109/ICSME.2016.42.

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